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Resonance

TL;DR

Resonance is a framework for cognitive resolution and diegetic game design.

Resonance Core provides the generic engine.

Resonance Prisms transform that engine into the logic of a particular world.

Glorantha Perspectives demonstrates one complete implementation.

The system does not define the world.

The world defines the system.

And when the mechanics become an extension of the fiction,

the player no longer plays the rules.

They play the world.

A framework for cognitive resolution and diegetic game design.

Resonance is not a roleplaying game.

It is a framework for designing roleplaying games where **resolution emerges from the fiction itself.**

Instead of asking:

What is my character's percentage chance of success?

Resonance asks:

What, in this character and in this situation, actually matters right now?

The player looks at the scene.

They identify what matters.

They bring the relevant elements of the fiction into the resolution.

Then the dice answer.

No character-sheet calculations.

No search for the optimal modifier.

No mechanical interface between the player and the world.

The rule becomes an extension of the player's perception.

The idea behind Resonance

Most roleplaying games put a mechanical system between the player and the fictional world.

A character has attributes.

Those attributes become numbers.

Numbers become modifiers.

Modifiers interact with probabilities.

And eventually, a result tells us what happens.

Resonance takes a different approach.

The fiction comes first.

When a character attempts something, the player naturally considers:

- who the character is;
- what they have experienced;
- what they know;
- what they are carrying;
- who is helping them;
- what the environment is doing;
- what they fear;
- what they want;
- what stands in their way.

These elements are already meaningful.

Resonance simply gives them mechanical weight.

The question is not:

How good are you at this?

It is:

What gives you leverage here?

That is the fundamental idea behind **Resonance Core**.

Resonance Core

A generic engine for resolving uncertainty through fiction.

Resonance Core is the generic resolution engine at the heart of Resonance.

It does not define a setting.

It does not define a genre.

It does not define how characters progress.

It does not tell you what magic looks like, how combat works, or what the world believes.

It provides something simpler:

a way to turn what matters in a fictional situation into a resolution.

This is where Resonance introduces one of its fundamental concepts: the **Bet**.

The Bets

Resonance uses a specific term for the fictional elements that can influence a resolution:

Bet.

A Bet is not an abstract modifier attached to a character sheet.

It is something that exists in the fiction before it exists in the mechanics.

A Bet is a fictional element that a player chooses to put into the balance of a resolution.

It can be anything that matters in the current situation:

- a skill;
- an experience;
- an object;
- a relationship;
- an emotion;
- an environmental condition;
- a weakness;
- a cultural trait;
- an advantage created by the situation;
- or any other element that genuinely matters in the fiction.

A skill is not automatically a Bet.

An advantage is not automatically a Bet.

It becomes a Bet when the player chooses to rely on it **here and now**.

Each Bet contributes to the resolution pool.

You are not calculating how good your character is.

You are deciding **what you are betting matters**.

In that sense, a Bet is a hypothesis about what will matter in the situation.

You may hope that your experience with the spear will give you the upper hand.

You may fear that your injured leg will weigh against you.

You may believe that the enemy's fear will make them hesitate.

The dice then test those bets against the opposing side's bets.

For example:

My character is wounded.

The bridge is collapsing.

I know this language.

The enemy is afraid.

It is raining.

If that fact genuinely matters to the situation, it can become a Bet.

Bets are not the same as stakes.

The **stakes** are what is at risk or what can be gained or lost in the situation.

A **Bet** is something from the fiction that is placed into the balance because it may influence those stakes.

For example:

Stakes: Cross the river before the guards arrive.

Bets: The character knows the river, the current is unusually strong, their companion is injured, and night is falling.

Stakes define what can be won or lost.

Bets define what each side believes may influence the outcome.

This distinction is important.

A Bet is not necessarily an advantage.

It can be something that helps you or something that works against you.

You can bet on your own strength.

You can bet on an opponent's weakness.

You can even bet on a dangerous circumstance if you believe it will influence the resolution in your favor.

The important question is not whether something is objectively good or bad.

The question is:

Are you betting that it matters?

1. See the situation

The table establishes what is happening.

Not everything on the character sheet matters.

Not everything in the world matters.

The group determines what is relevant **now**.

This is the **Focus**.

2. Identify the Bets

Each side identifies the elements of the fiction that support its objective or hinder the opposing objective.

These elements become **Bets**.

The process is not about finding every possible advantage.

It is about identifying what genuinely matters in the current situation.

A character may have exceptional swordsmanship.

But if the current conflict is a political negotiation, that ability may not be a Bet.

A character may have a debt to the person they are negotiating with.

That relationship might be.

The Focus determines what enters the resolution.

3. Resolve

The relevant Bets determine the size of the resolution pool.

The dice are rolled.

But the dice do not decide everything on their own.

The way the dice are interpreted depends on the game's Prisms.

This is where Resonance becomes capable of adapting to radically different worlds.

4. Interpret

The result is not an isolated number.

It is a change in the fiction.

A narrow victory.

A decisive victory.

A failure.

A catastrophe.

A stalemate.

The resolution exists to answer the dramatic question and move the story forward.

Roll → interpret → fiction changes.

A resolution without an interface

Imagine a character trying to cross a dangerous battlefield.

A traditional system might ask:

What is your movement score?

What is the difficulty?

Do you have a bonus?

What is your final modifier?

Resonance asks something else:

What matters here?

Perhaps:

- the character knows how armies move;
- their brother is waiting on the other side;
- artillery is falling around them;
- they are carrying an injured companion;
- the enemy has spotted them.

Those elements can become Bets — if the player chooses to rely on them.

The player is not searching their character sheet for a number.

They are looking at the world.

They may hope that their knowledge of the battlefield will help.

They may fear that carrying an injured companion will slow them down.

They may decide that the enemy having spotted them is actually useful because it draws attention away from their companions.

The player is not calculating probabilities.

They are making a judgment about what matters.

That is the cognitive experience Resonance is designed to create.

Resonance Prisms

A framework for designing how fiction responds to resolution.

The Core deliberately leaves something open:

What does the world believe is true?

This is the role of **Prisms**.

A Prism defines how the fiction of a particular game transforms and interprets uncertainty.

The same Core can therefore produce radically different experiences.

A materialist world may treat the dice as indifferent physical probability.

A world ruled by gods may allow faith to alter outcomes.

An animist world may allow spirits to intervene.

A mystical world may treat apparent success and failure as illusions.

A technological world might turn patterns, sequences or calculations into meaningful outcomes.

The Core stays the same.

The Prism changes what the dice mean.

The Prism is the philosophy of the world made mechanical.

A good Prism answers questions such as:

What does this universe consider true?

What does it consider possible?

What does it reward?

What does it punish?

What does it make dangerous?

How does the world's philosophy affect uncertainty?

The result is a powerful inversion of traditional game design.

Instead of:

Rules → fiction

Resonance aims for:

Fiction → rules

The lore is no longer merely something players read.

It becomes something they use.

One engine. Different realities.

The Core can remain fundamentally unchanged while the Prism transforms the experience.

For example:

Theism

Pairs succeed.

Sixes can create extraordinary outcomes and interact with otherwise failed results.

Faith changes what failure means.

Animism

Pairs succeed.

Certain patterns among failed dice can become successful outcomes.

The world is populated by possibilities that do not behave like ordinary causality.

Logic

The dice are not interpreted as simple success/failure.

Their values are accumulated and processed according to a deterministic rule.

Uncertainty becomes calculation.

Mysticism

Certain results can negate the apparent successes of an opponent.

Material victory becomes secondary to a deeper reality.

These are not cosmetic variations.

They create different cognitive experiences.

The player does not simply learn the world's lore.

The player thinks through the world's philosophy.

Resonance: Glorantha

A concrete implementation.

A framework becomes interesting when it can leave the page.

Resonance: Glorantha demonstrates what happens when Resonance is fully embedded in a specific fictional world.

Glorantha is not simply given a generic resolution system.

Its cosmology, religions and ways of understanding reality become part of the resolution itself.

The same underlying engine can therefore feel radically different depending on whether a character approaches reality through:

Theism.

Animism.

Logic.

Mysticism.

Or other ways of understanding the world.

This is the purpose of Resonance Prisms in practice:

The system does not merely describe the world.

It makes the player experience the world through its own logic.

Explore the implementation

Glorantha Perspectives is the proof of concept and the detailed implementation of the framework.

Read the Glorantha Perspectives SRD →

Designed for worlds that matter

Resonance is particularly suited to games where the world itself is important.

Worlds with:

- deep lore;
- competing philosophies;
- meaningful cultures;
- strange metaphysics;
- strong relationships;
- symbolic environments;
- worlds where *how you understand reality* matters as much as what you can physically do.

Because the mechanics do not need to encode every possible action separately, the same Core can handle:

a duel, a negotiation, an investigation, a ritual, a chase, a battle, a journey or a political conflict.

The resolution changes because the **fiction changes**, not because a new subsystem has to be learned.

Designed for game designers

Resonance changes the role of the game designer.

You do not primarily have to design:

- hundreds of modifiers;
- exhaustive skill lists;
- rules for every possible situation;
- increasingly complex combat subsystems.

Instead, you design the things that make your world unique.

You create the fiction.

Its:

lore.

beliefs.

cultures.

relationships.

myths.

taboos.

metaphysics.

You define what can matter.

What can become a Bet?

What should never become one?

What does the game want players to notice?

You design the Prisms.

How does this world respond to uncertainty?

How does its philosophy alter resolution?

What happens when a character acts against the fundamental logic of the world?

You define the boundaries.

What is impossible?

What is forbidden?

What cannot simply be overcome by adding another argument?

These are the design decisions that give a Resonance game its identity.

What Resonance is trying to change

Roleplaying games have become extraordinarily good at modelling different things.

Some systems model progression.

Some model physical reality.
Some model genres.
Some model dramatic negotiation.
Resonance focuses on something different:

Relevance.

What matters to this character,
in this situation,
right now?
That sounds simple.
But it changes the player's behaviour.
Players stop asking:

What is my best modifier?

and start asking:

What can I see?

What do I know?

What does my character believe?

What is happening around me?

What is actually at stake?

And that is the experience Resonance is built to support.
